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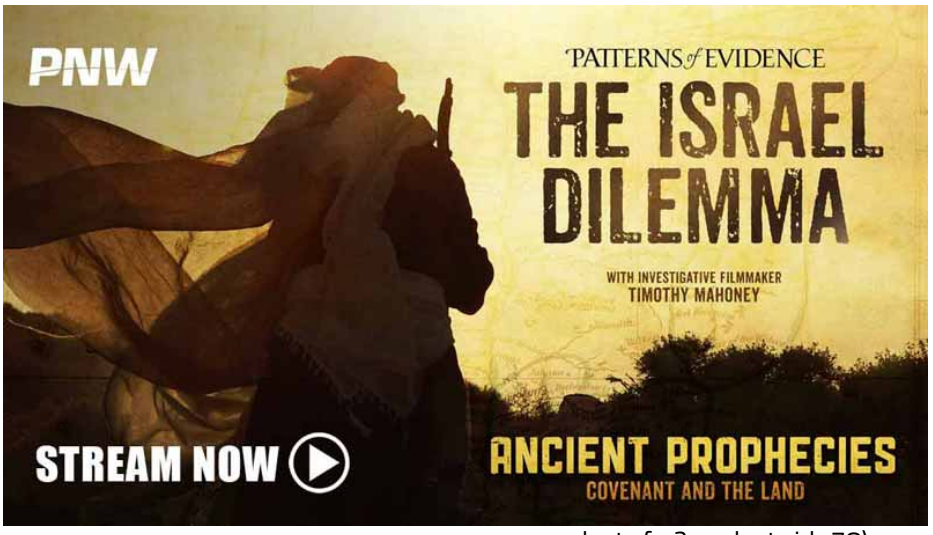
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ARTICLE

Hungary Is A Warning: What Will Survive The Post-Trump Reckoning?



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 06, 2026

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Viktor Orbán spent 16 years building a political system in Hungary that many assumed would outlive him.



It took his successors only months to begin tearing major pieces of it apart.

That may be the most important lesson coming out of Hungary right now—not whether Americans admire Orbán, dislike him, or even understand Hungarian politics. It is how quickly the accomplishments of a powerful political leader can begin disappearing once his opponents inherit the machinery of government.

Péter Magyar defeated Orbán in April in a stunning election victory that gave his Tisza Party a two-thirds parliamentary majority. Magyar had promised Hungarians something bigger than replacing one prime minister with another. He promised what amounted to a change of system.

And that is what followed.

Hungary's president was pushed out through a constitutional amendment terminating his mandate. The chief prosecutor resigned under political pressure. Secret-service chiefs were dismissed. The head of the counterterrorism police was removed. Constitutional rules were changed, Orbán-era institutions were targeted, and the government began dismantling what Magyar and his supporters regarded as entrenched remnants of 16 years of Fidesz rule.

The changes have been so sweeping that analysts have described them as a constitutional "reset." Supporters say Hungary is restoring democratic institutions after years of Orbán consolidating power. Fidesz argues that Magyar is using his enormous parliamentary majority to purge political opponents and rewrite the rules for his own advantage.

Whichever interpretation ultimately proves closer to reality, Americans should pay attention to something much simpler:

Political legacies can be remarkably fragile.



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Donald Trump has spent his second presidency attempting something far more ambitious than passing a few tax cuts or changing a handful of regulations.

He has attempted to fundamentally redirect the federal government.

DEI programs have been dismantled across federal agencies. Immigration enforcement has been dramatically expanded. Federal personnel policies have changed. Environmental and energy regulations have been reversed. Gender-identity policies have been rewritten. Agencies have been reorganized, funding priorities altered, and executive power aggressively employed to force Washington in a very different direction.

Trump's DEI orders alone directed federal agencies to terminate DEI offices, positions, equity plans, grants, contracts and related requirements to the maximum extent permitted by law.

The question is no longer simply what Trump can change.

The more consequential question may be: How much of it survives him?

Because Trump's opponents are already thinking about the government that comes afterward.

The Washington Post reported this week that Trump critics, particularly Democrats, are developing proposals aimed at reversing significant changes associated with his presidency and restricting presidential powers they believe Trump has abused. Those ideas include new limits on emergency powers, tougher ethics requirements and changes designed to insulate institutions such as the Justice Department from presidential influence.

That doesn't mean every proposal will become law. It does demonstrate that the post-Trump conversation has already begun.

And Hungary shows how quickly that conversation can become government policy when political power changes hands.



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The First Signature Could Erase The Last One

This is where Trump's legacy faces an enormous vulnerability.

A law passed by Congress cannot simply be eliminated because a new president dislikes it.

An executive order can.

Regulations can be rewritten. Enforcement priorities can change. Federal funding can be redirected within legal limits. Agency leadership can be replaced. Foreign policy can shift dramatically. New administrations can reinterpret regulations and begin reversing their predecessors' administrative actions.

What Trump accomplished through presidential power can, in many instances, eventually be attacked through presidential power.

Imagine another administration arriving in Washington determined to produce its own "reset."

Immigration enforcement could change direction.

Federal DEI initiatives could return under new terminology.

Climate and environmental regulations could be rebuilt.

Title IX and gender-identity rules could shift again.

Federal agencies reorganized under Trump could be reorganized again.

Trump-appointed officials could be replaced wherever the law permits.

Funding priorities could move back toward organizations and programs Trump opposed.

This isn't speculation about some secret plan. It is largely how the American administrative state operates when control of the executive branch changes parties.

The difference after Trump may be the scale.

Then Come The Investigations

There is another part of the post-Trump landscape that is already taking shape.

Democratic lawmakers aren't hiding their intention to conduct aggressive investigations if they regain congressional power.

Reuters reported September 28 that Democrats are preparing investigations involving Trump's family business dealings and associated companies if they capture either chamber of Congress. Democratic leader Hakeem Jeffries declared that Democrats would begin holding people they believe engaged in wrongdoing accountable "on day one."

Other Democratic lawmakers have discussed subpoenas, hearings, document demands and investigations involving administration officials and outside organizations. House Democrats are developing an extensive oversight agenda spanning multiple committees, with impeachment of Trump or Cabinet officials not categorically ruled out.

Democrats describe this as legitimate congressional oversight and accountability. The Trump White House describes the prospective investigations as politically motivated attempts to obstruct the administration.

But consider the larger picture.

First comes reversing the policies.

Then restructuring the institutions.

Then replacing the personnel.

Then investigating the people who built the previous system.

Hungary demonstrates just how much can change when all those forces begin moving simultaneously.

Sixteen Years Can Disappear Surprisingly Fast

Orbán's system wasn't constructed overnight.

Beginning in 2010, Fidesz reshaped Hungary's constitution, courts, media environment and government institutions. Orbán's supporters saw much of this as reclaiming Hungarian sovereignty and traditional values. His critics regarded it as systematic consolidation of political power.

Either way, it was built over 16 years.

Then Orbán lost.

Within months, Hungary's president was gone. The chief prosecutor was gone. Security officials were gone. Constitutional arrangements were being rewritten. Orbán himself was constitutionally blocked from returning as prime minister, and institutions designed during the Fidesz era were being dismantled.

That is the warning from Hungary.

Political movements naturally celebrate what happens while their side controls government. Executive orders are signed. Regulations disappear. agencies change direction. Policies long demanded by voters finally become reality.

But history doesn't stop on Inauguration Day.

Eventually another election comes.

And sometimes the people entering government aren't interested in merely governing differently.

They want to dismantle what came before them.

Trump has spent his second presidency trying to transform Washington. The ultimate measure of that transformation, however, may not be what Washington looks like on Trump's final day in office.

It may be what remains several years later.

Because Hungary is demonstrating an uncomfortable truth about modern politics:

Building a political revolution is one thing.

Building one that survives the people who built it is something else entirely.

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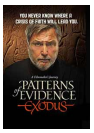
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